TRIBAL FIRST

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DROUPADI MURMU
President of India

Droupadi Murmu, India's first president from the adivasi community, has avoided political controversy thus far

By Romita Datta

The journey from the remote Uparbeda village in the Mayurbhanj district of Odisha to Raisina Hill in Delhi had been long and arduous. As India's first president from the tribal community, Droupadi Murmu summed it all up in her first address to the nation after her appointment: "Reaching this office isn't my personal achievement but that of all poor people. My election is proof... that in India the poor can dream and fulfil their dreams." Murmu was working for the adivasis when the BJP's Raj Kishore Das saw in her an immense potential that could help the party grow among tribals. At every level of her career—councillor, MLA and then cabinet minister of a BJD-BJP government—her priority was to improve the lot of villagers. When she was governor of Jharkhand (2015-2021), the BJP government passed amendments to the Chhotanagpur Tenancy Act and the Santhal Parganas Tenancy Act to facilitate easy transfer of tribal land for industrial use. If passed, the laws would have hurt the adivasis. Murmu returned the bills in June 2017, running the risk of antagonising the party. Political exigency played a part in the BJP projecting Murmu as president. Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan go to the polls in 2023; the BJP fared poorly in seats reserved for SCs/STs in MP and Chhattisgarh in 2018. Shifting allegiance of tribal voters is apparent in Jharkhand too. In Murmu, the BJP found a pivot to take the tribal narrative forward. She won the presidential polls handsomely and was sworn in on July 25. Since she assumed office, the BJP has tried to use her tribal background to make inroads into various *vanvasi* communities. Murmu, on her part, has avoided political controversy and meets politicians from all parties.

Behind the choice of Murmu as president lay the BJP's waning influence amongst tribals

As president, Murmu has spoken about how the poor face delayed justice due to the high cost of litigation. On Human Rights Day on December 10, she spoke about the need to protect all living beings along with their habitat to ensure equal rights for all. ■



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